Dental Claim Status Note Template

One note format that lets anyone pick up a claim cold

A claim sits for weeks and then someone new opens it. If the ledger note says only "called payer", nobody learns anything. Use this template on every insurance follow-up so the next reader knows exactly where the claim stands and what happens next.

1. The header, every time

- [ ] Date, time and the initials of whoever made the contact.
- [ ] Patient name, member ID and the plan being worked, including primary or secondary.
- [ ] Claim date of service, codes and tooth numbers on the line in question.
- [ ] Payer name, the reference or claim number they quote back, and the method used: portal, phone, fax, clearinghouse.

2. The status line

- [ ] State where the claim is, in plain words, not how you felt about it: "received by payer 14 Oct, no adjudication record yet".
- [ ] Quote the payer's own status language and any adjustment or reason code exactly.
- [ ] If you spoke to a person, include the first name and any case number they gave you.
- [ ] Never write "waiting" without a date attached to what you are waiting for.

3. The action taken

- [ ] What you actually did: resent the claim, uploaded an attachment, requested a reprocess, asked for a supervisor.
- [ ] Include the confirmation number for anything transmitted, in the note, not only in the sent folder.
- [ ] If you requested documentation from the payer, write down who was asked and by when.
- [ ] Note anything the patient was told in the same conversation, so the front desk is not surprised later.

4. The next step

- [ ] One action, one owner, one date. Two next steps means neither happens.

- [ ] Set the follow-up date to the payer's stated turnaround, not to a generic 14 days, when they give you a number.
- [ ] Write the escalation path now: who to call if this step fails, so the next reader does not start over.
- [ ] If the balance is becoming the patient's, note when and how they were told.

5. Worked examples

- [ ] Stuck in transmission: "10/14 Called Payer X ref 5521993. Claim not on their system. Clearinghouse confirms accepted 10/02, control 8812. Action: resubmit with original DOS and note. Owner: R. Next check 10/21."
- [ ] Documentation requested: "10/14 Portal shows claim pended for perio chart + pre-op film. Action: upload chart dated 9/28 and PANO. Confirmation 4471. Owner: S. Next check 10/28."
- [ ] Bundled denial: "10/14 EOB: D2950 bundled with D2740 per plan policy. Policy page saved to ledger. Action: no appeal - patient estimate corrected, balance moved to guarantor. Owner: M. Note added to payer rule list."
- [ ] Payment posted wrong: "10/14 EFT 31220 posted to wrong patient, same family. Action: request reassignment letter from payer. Owner: R. Next check 10/20. Timely filing safe."

6. Rules that keep notes useful

- [ ] Write for the person who inherits the claim in three weeks, not for yourself today.
- [ ] No acronyms nobody else in the office uses.
- [ ] Log the contact even when it changes nothing - silence is also a status.
- [ ] Keep the note in one place per claim. Split notes across ledger, spreadsheet and email is how claims go cold.
- [ ] Audit a handful of notes monthly against the payer portal to catch the ones that were never really followed up.

Bottom line: The test is simple: hand the note to someone who has never seen the claim. If they can tell you what happens next and by when, your follow-up process will hold when you are not in the room.